THE SCIENTIST AND THE DANCER

While in Bangalore in his early twenties, Sarabhai fell in love with and married the Bharatanatyam dancer Mrinalini Swaminathan. Mrinalini was the daughter of Ammu Swaminathan and the sister of Lakshmi Sahgal, both of whom also appear in this book.



APJ Abdul Kalam was one of the first recruits to join the emerging space programme under Vikram Sarabhai. He eventually went on to become the head of India's missile development programme, and later served as India's 11th president.

To space and beyond

Sarabhai is best known for spearheading India's space programme. He believed that satellites offered enormous opportunities for scientific research, and could be used to beam education into remote, inaccessible regions. It was a way to harness cutting-edge science for social change, something Sarabhai strongly supported. In order to help India set up its own space programme, Sarabhai worked with various government departments as well as NASA and other international agencies to secure both technological expertise and funding. He oversaw the launch of India's first rocket on 21 November 1963, and was instrumental in setting up the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) in 1969. Since then, ISRO has made great progress, from launching India's first satellite (named Aryabhata) in 1975 to